Broccoli and shallots add color and freshness to this rich combination of potato and cheese. You can use Caerphilly or Wensleydale in place of the mascarpone.

potato soup with broccoli, shallots, and mascarpone

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 40 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

1 tbsp olive oil
¾ tbsp butter
2 large shallots, finely chopped
12oz (350g) floury potatoes, chopped into 1in (2.5cm) chunks
sea salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 large head of broccoli, cut into florets
4 tbsp mascarpone
4 croûtes (see p39)
1oz (30g) creamy, strong-flavored blue cheese, such as Roquefort, fourme d'Ambert, or Gorgonzola piquante

1 Heat the oil and butter in a sauté pan over medium heat, add the shallots and potatoes, and cook for 5 minutes, stirring often. Meanwhile, boil 1½ quarts (1½ liters) water in a teapot or on the stove.

2 Pour 1¼ quarts (1¼ liters) boiling water into the pan and stir well. Season lightly with sea salt and freshly ground black pepper and bring to a simmer. Lower the heat, cover with a lid, and simmer for 10 minutes. Add the broccoli, stir, cover again, and continue cooking for 10–15 minutes or until the vegetables are tender. Let cool for several minutes, then transfer the contents of the pan to a blender and process until smooth. Strain the soup back into the pan through a sieve, using a wooden spoon to push as much of the mixture through as possible.

3 Pour in the rest of the hot water. Place the pan over medium heat, stir in the mascarpone, and keep stirring until it has blended in. Season with salt and freshly ground black pepper. Spread the croûtes with the blue cheese, ladle the soup into bowls, and float a piece in the center of each one.